New Hunger Games Movie Keeps a Secret About Haymitch and Maysilee

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The Hunger Games: Sunrise on the Reaping comes to theaters on November 20, 2026. It is from Suzanne Collins's 2025 book. The story follows Haymitch Abernathy, played by Joseph Zada, and Maysilee Donner, played by McKenna Grace, two **tributes** from District 12.

Director Francis Lawrence has directed every Hunger Games movie except the first. He spent a lot of time with Zada and Grace in **rehearsals** in Spain, talking about the pair. The three kept some secrets about the pair's **bond** to shape how the characters act.

One detail stands out: even though Haymitch and Maysilee have known each other all their lives, she slams the door in his face. Lawrence said Collins may not have written about other parts of their story.

Fans may know the pair from Catching Fire (2009), in which Katniss Everdeen and Peeta Mellark watch **footage** of the 50th Games, where the pair teamed up against double the usual number of **tributes**. This time there are four District 12 **tributes**, not two. The youngest is Louella McCoy, protected by Haymitch since they were playground **sweethearts**.

Word Treasure

tributes -- People chosen to take part in a contest for their district.

rehearsals -- Practice sessions where actors work on a movie before they perform it.

footage -- Video of something that happened.

bond -- A close feeling of friendship and trust between people.

sweethearts -- Two people who are very fond of each other, like a young couple.

Background you need

The Hunger Games is a story about young people from different districts who are picked as tributes for a big contest.

Haymitch Abernathy and Maysilee Donner are two tributes from District 12, and the new movie follows their story.

The pair already appeared in an earlier story, where other characters watched footage of their Games.

Break it down

WHO: Haymitch Abernathy and Maysilee Donner, two tributes from District 12, played by Joseph Zada and McKenna Grace.

WHAT: A new movie about the pair, with secrets about their bond kept by the director and the two actors during rehearsals.

WHERE: Rehearsals in Spain, and the movie in theaters.

WHY: Because the director and actors kept secrets about the pair's bond to shape how the characters act.

Why it matters

It can help you notice how friendships and secrets between characters shape the stories you watch.

Test what you remember

1. Who plays Haymitch Abernathy in the new movie?

- (A) Joseph Zada
- (B) Suzanne Collins
- (C) McKenna Grace
- (D) Francis Lawrence

2. How many District 12 tributes are there this time?

- (A) Three
- (B) Four
- (C) Two
- (D) Five

3. Where did Francis Lawrence spend time with Joseph Zada and McKenna Grace in rehearsals?

- (A) A studio in Los Angeles
- (B) District 12
- (C) Spain
- (D) A theater in London

4. What does Maysilee do to Haymitch, even though they have known each other all their lives?

- (A) She slams the door in his face
- (B) She watches footage of his Games
- (C) She protects him on the playground
- (D) She writes a book about him

5. Who is the youngest District 12 tribute?

- (A) Haymitch Abernathy
- (B) Maysilee Donner
- (C) Katniss Everdeen
- (D) Louella McCoy

6. In the 50th Games, Haymitch and Maysilee teamed up against how many tributes?

- (A) Double the usual number of tributes
- (B) The usual number
- (C) Half the usual number
- (D) Only the District 12 tributes

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: C 4: A 5: D 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Francis Lawrence: He said Suzanne Collins may not have written about other parts of Haymitch and Maysilee's story.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):